

JOUR 8500 RLA

**Mapping the Conceptual Boundaries Between Corporate
Social Responsibility (CSR) and
Corporate Social Advocacy (CSA):**

A Topic Modeling and Word Embedding Analysis via *PR-Embed*

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Date: Apr 9, 2026

Huang, J., Hurst, B., Capizzo, L. W., & Zhou, A. (2026). Mapping conceptual boundaries: Using structural topic modeling and word embedding to contrast CSA and CSR in public relations research. Working Paper

Background

- **Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR):** the “economic, legal, ethical and discretionary [later termed philanthropic] expectations that society has of organizations at a given point of time.”
- **Corporate Social Advocacy (CSA):** “an organization making a public statement or taking a public stance on social-political issues”
- How *CSR* and *CSA* have been conceptualized in public relations scholarship?

Methods

- **Dataset:**
 - Past 20 years
 - Full articles in six public relations journals
 - Pre-processing: lemmatization and stopword removal.

Table 1

Overview of the 20-Year Full-Text Dataset across Six Public Relations Journals (2004–2024)

Journal	Collected	Removed	Final	Total Words	Years
<i>Corporate Communications: An International Journal (CC)</i>	800	78	722	4,144,671	2004–2024
<i>International Journal of Strategic Communication (IJSC)</i>	421	20	401	2,852,185	2007–2024
<i>Journal of Communication Management (JCM)</i>	576	48	528	3,222,198	2004–2024
<i>Journal of Public Relations Research (JPRR)</i>	467	72	395	2,932,836	2004–2024
<i>Public Relations Inquiry (PRI)</i>	280	69	211	1,506,547	2012–2024
<i>Public Relations Review (PRR)</i>	2,139	268	1,871	9,433,945	2004–2024
Total	4,683	555	4,128	24,092,382	2004–2024

Note: Removed articles are non-peer-reviewed publications, such as acknowledgment of reviewers, erratum, call for papers, and book reviews. All authors manually reviewed the dataset to delete these entries.

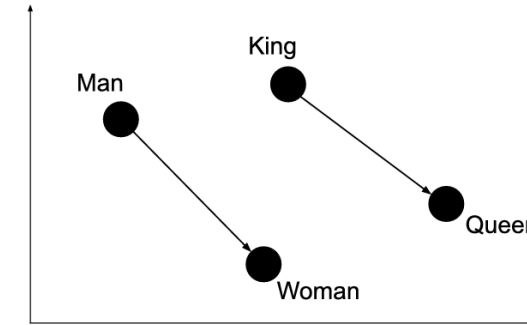
Methods

- **structural topic modeling (STM):**
 - What topics, represented by keywords, are present in a document and how prominently they feature
 - bag-of-words approach, disregard context
- **word embedding**
 - captures semantic relationships
 - recognizes terms such as CSR, ESG, and sustainability as similar to one another

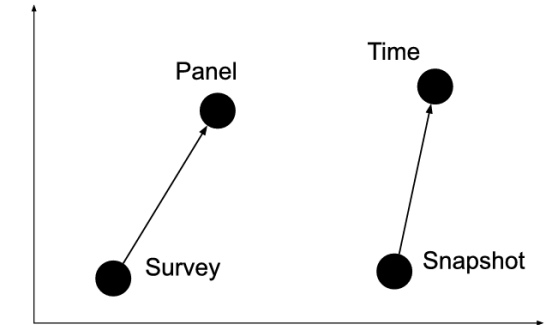
Figure 1

Word Embedding Illustrations

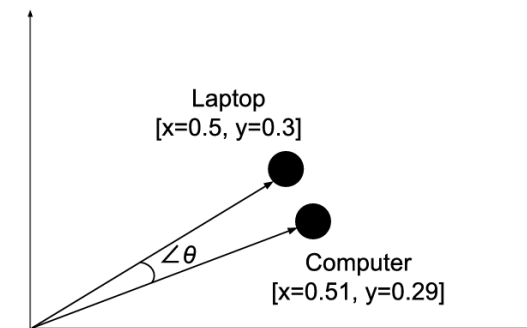
A. King - Man + Woman $\approx$ Queen



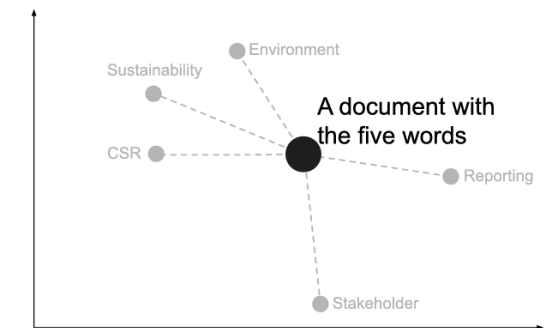
B. Survey - Snapshot + Time $\approx$ Panel



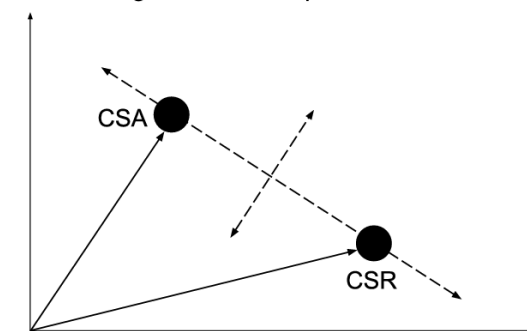
C. Small $\angle\theta$, High $\cos\theta$ (cosine similarity)



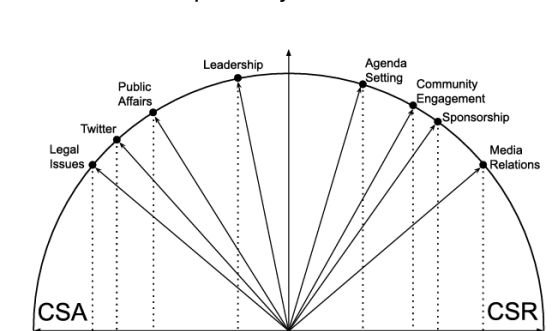
D. Average of word embeddings in a document



E. Creating a CSA-CSR Spectrum



F. Research Topics Projected



Note: Word embeddings typically exist in high-dimensional space; we use 2D for illustration. Panel A shows a semantic analogy. Panel B depicts domain-specific embedding. Panel C illustrates cosine similarity. Panel D shows document embedding via word vector averaging. Panel E forms a CSA-CSR semantic axis. Panel F projects example topics onto this axis.

Results

- **RQ1: Semantic Relationships Between CSR and CSA**
 - CSR: corporate structures, internal processes, and stakeholder routines
 - CSA: aligns with advocacy, legal positioning, authenticity concerns, and strategic adaptation in conflict.

Figure 2
Topic Distribution Along the CSA-CSR Spectrum

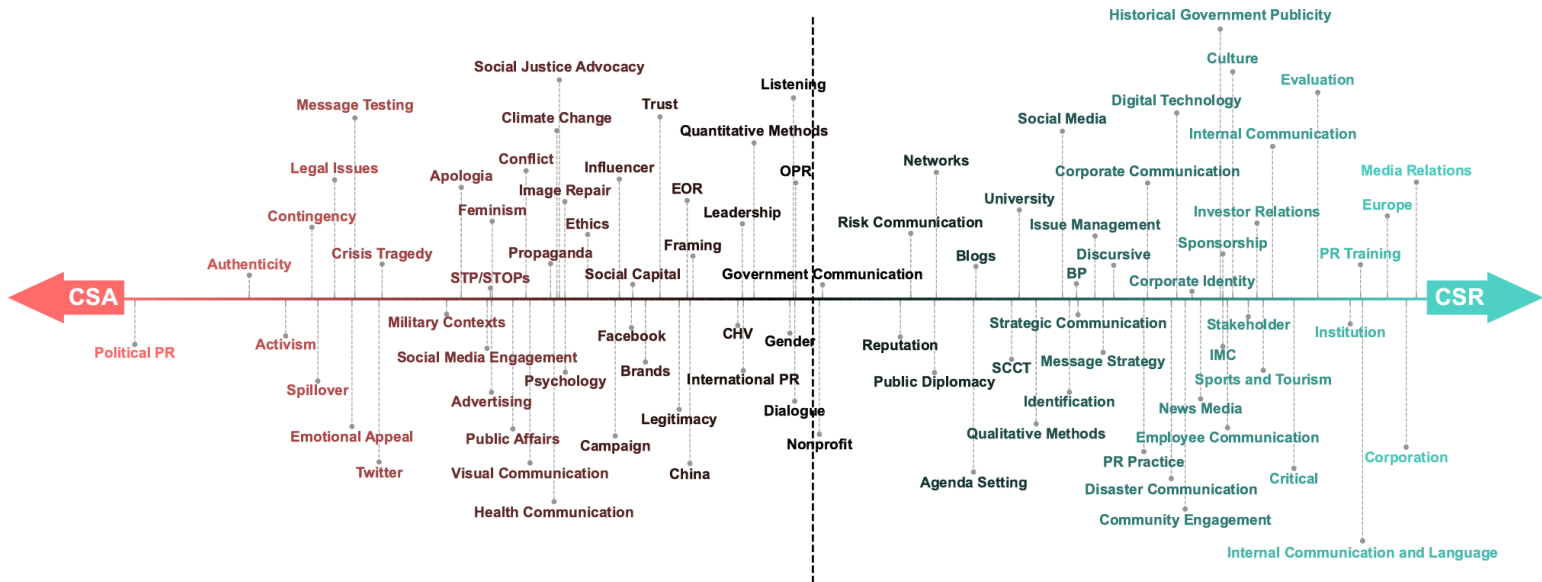


Table 3
Words Most Adjacent to CSA and CSR in Embeddings

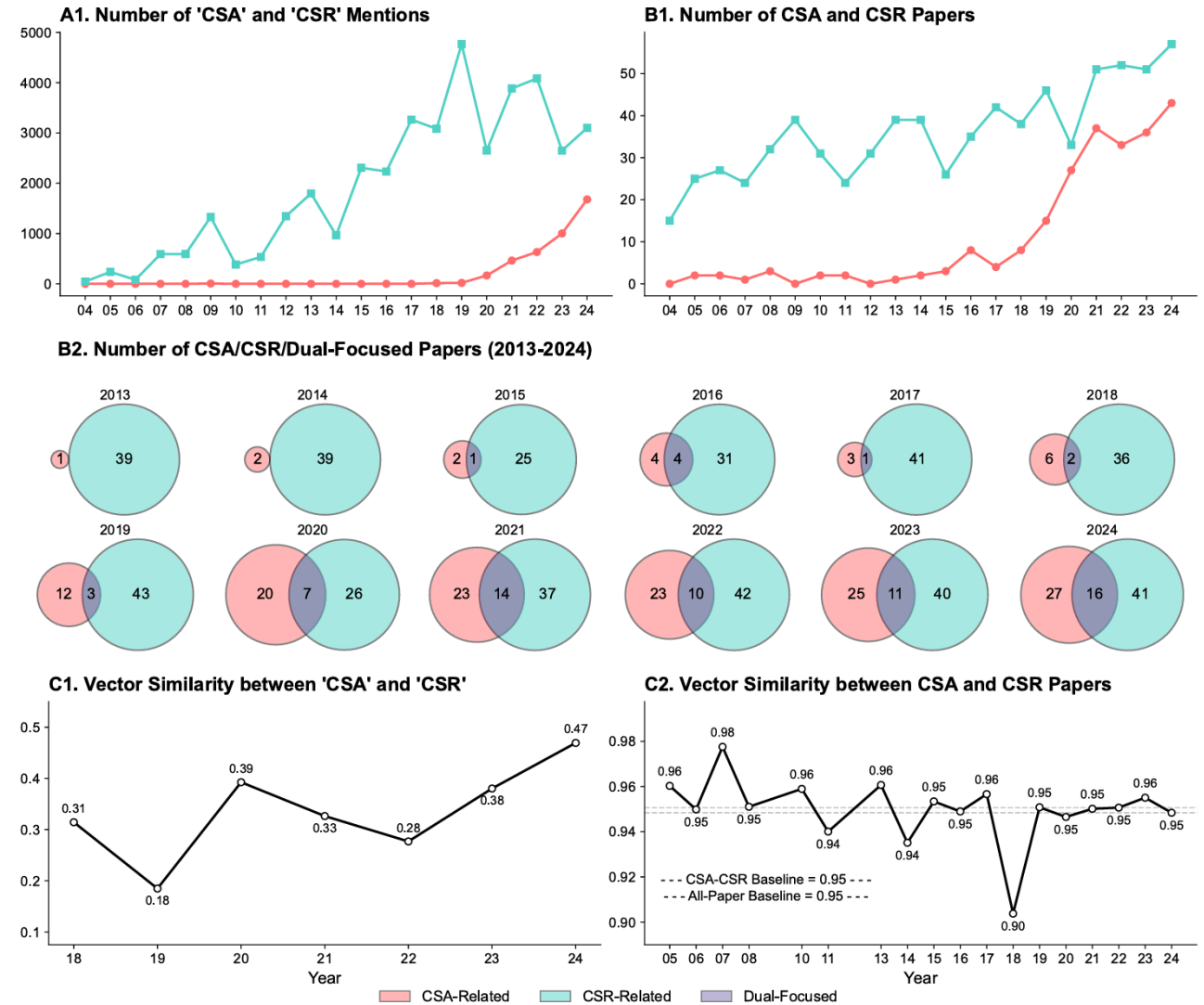
Rank	CSA	CSR
1	CPA (0.486)	Sustainability (0.537)
2	Sociopolitical (0.421)	Sus (0.496)
3	Activism (0.411)	ESG (0.460)
4	Femvertising (0.403)	Philanthropic (0.440)
5	Controversial (0.402)	Initiatives (0.436)
6	Authenticity (0.399)	Corporate (0.418)
7	Stances (0.393)	Philanthropy (0.392)
8	Nike (0.381)	Environmental (0.389)
9	OREO (0.380)	CD (0.377)
10	Stance (0.377)	Corporations (0.371)
11	Baur (0.374)	Morsing (0.365)
12	Congruence (0.372)	CA (0.356)
13	PWoM (0.370)	EVPs (0.356)
14	PIOC (0.368)	CSP (0.355)
15	eCSR (0.365)	DEI (0.354)
16	Brandstanding (0.365)	Company (0.352)
17	Supa (0.363)	Prosocial (0.350)
18	Advocacy (0.361)	Companies (0.350)
19	LGBTQ (0.357)	Postcrisis (0.349)
20	Attenuated (0.356)	CSRC (0.348)

Results

- **RQ2: Longitudinal Trends of CSR and CSA**
 - Mentions (A1)
 - Number of papers (B1)
 - Overlap between categories (B2)
 - Evolving semantic relationship (term) (C1)
 - Evolving semantic relationship (papers) (C2)

Figure 3

Longitudinal Trend of CSR and CSA Scholarship



Notes. Panel A shows yearly mentions of “CSA” and “CSR.” Panel B1 reports CSA- and CSR-related paper counts based on STM results. Panel B2 (2013-2024) uses Venn diagrams to show overlap. Panel C1 plots yearly cosine similarity between the two words “CSA” and “CSR.” Panel C2 shows average similarity between CSA- and CSR-related papers, with CSA-CSR baseline and all-paper baseline shown in comparison.

Results

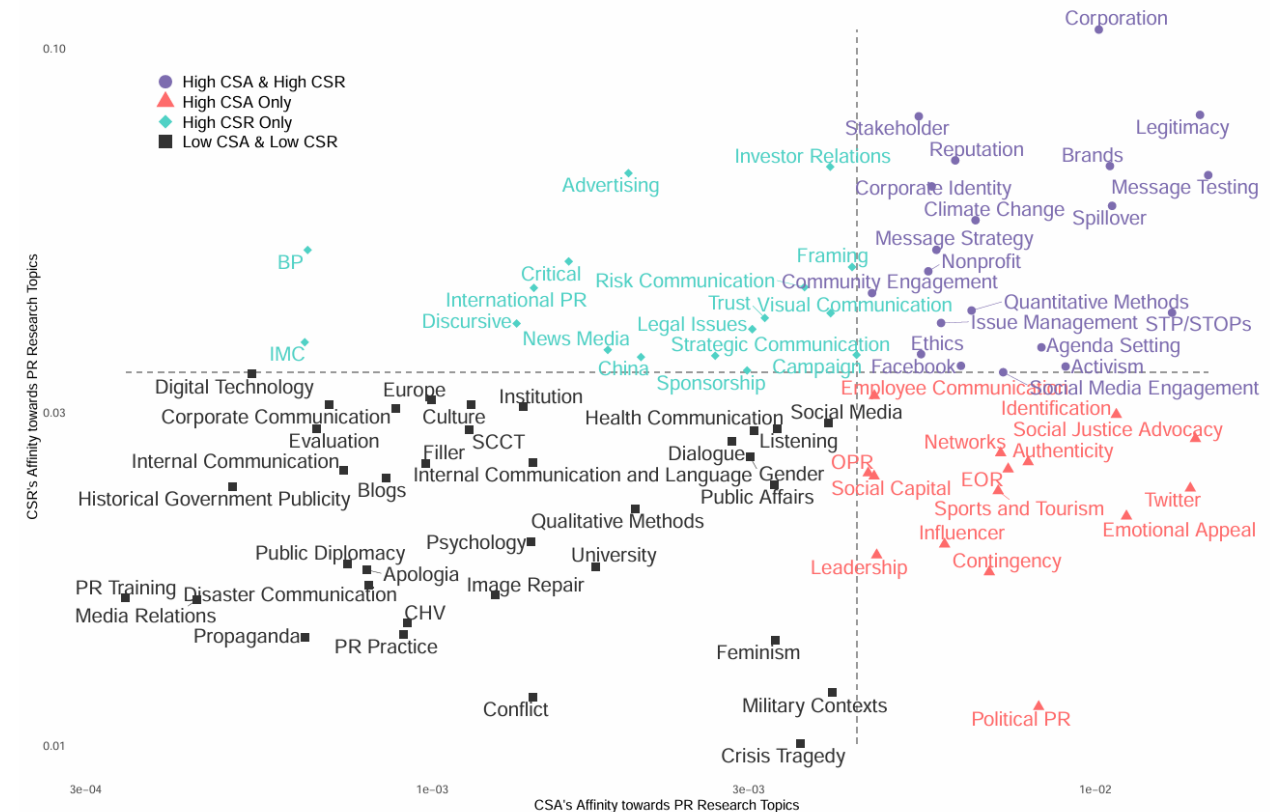
• RQ3: Charting Habitual Minds When Writing About CSR and CSA

Four categories

- CSA exhibits lower average affinity with other research topics compared to CSR
- CSA scholarship lacks the established topical routines—or “habitual mind”

Figure 4

CSA/CSR Topic's Affinity Towards Other Research Topics



Discussion

- CSA's emphasis on **polarization and politicization** has functioned as a key point of conceptual distinction from CSR. (RQ1)
- Growing **linguistic convergence** between CSR and CSA. (RQ2)
- CSA lacks the established topical routines—or “habitual mind” (RQ3)
- CSR and CSA retain distinctive conceptual roots, their conceptual overlap and convergence continue to expand, with both positive and negative implications.

Questions

- **Figure 3.**

- (C1) Why do the trends of the two graphs appear to be opposite in the ranges of 18-22 and 23-24? (Jiarou)
- (A1 B1 C1 C2) No significant indicator in line graph, how to determine if these fluctuations are meaningful or merely random variations? (Jiarou)
- (C2) There are no clear difference between the two baselines, how to determine which one belongs to the CSA-CSR baseline and which one belongs to all-paper? (Jiarou)
- What kind of y-axis scale should be used when presenting data in figures? (Jikai)

Questions

- **Figure 4.**

- Which quadrant represents CSR–CSA, CSR-more, CSA-more, and neither? What does this distance and clustering indicate in terms of the method and the context? (Namuun)
- Whether the figure could be improved by simplifying some visual elements? (Wenwen)
- How the coordinate axes of this graph and the positions of the different points were calculated? (Jiarou)